

The Columbian Exchange

©LMS/13

The Columbian Exchange

•The voyages of Columbus began a vast exchange between the hemispheres – between the “Old” world and the “New”. This exchange involved culture, plants, people, livestock, and even diseases. Because this exchange was started by Columbus’ voyages, it is often referred to as the ‘*Columbian Exchange*’.



Traveling from ‘New’ World to ‘Old’

•The foods from the New world were probably the most important products exchanged with the Old world. Some of the foods that traveled from the Americas to Europe (and beyond) were:

potatoes, tomatoes, squash, corn, beans, avacados and peanuts.



•The two most important food products were corn and potatoes – both were easy and inexpensive to grow, and were very nutritious. The potato in particular, became a *staple* food in many nations in Europe and in Asia. In fact, the potato did more to combat starvation and grow the world’s population than any rulers or inventions had done.

•Both *vanilla* and *cacao* (chocolate) beans came from the Americas. Chocolate, of course, would become a specialty of certain European countries (Switzerland, Belgium...)



•*Turkey* was a New World poultry that became an important food source for many in the Eastern Hemisphere.

•Two drugs that came from the new world were *tobacco* and *quinine*. Quinine was later discovered to be effective against malaria.

Traveling from ‘Old’ World to ‘New’

•A number of food products moved from the Old world to the New, including: *citrus fruits, peaches, pears, grapes, bananas, olives, onions, sugar cane and coffee*. (Yes, coffee, bananas and oranges were NOT native to the New World!)

•In addition, Europeans brought a number of grain products like *wheat, rice, barley and oats* to the New World.



•Europeans also introduced livestock into the Americas, including: *cattle, sheep, pigs and horses*. (Herds of wild mustangs roaming the countryside? No, not until Europeans brought them!)



Aside from the llama, the Americas were devoid of beasts of burden!

•Unfortunately, some of the European contributions to the Americas were devastating. They introduced a number of diseases including *smallpox, influenza, typhus, measles, malaria, diphtheria and whooping cough*.



•These diseases were deadly to Europeans even though they had some immunity. This immunity was built up over thousands of years of exposure to these diseases.

•The natives of the New World had never been exposed to these diseases, and they had no immunity. This created epidemics and massive death tolls. It also contributed to the fall of the Aztec and Inca Empires.

•It is difficult to establish the exact death toll across Latin America, because there are few population records. But, as one example, scholars believe the population of the Aztec Empire to be 15 million in 1521, but only 2 million in 1581.